Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

May 2026

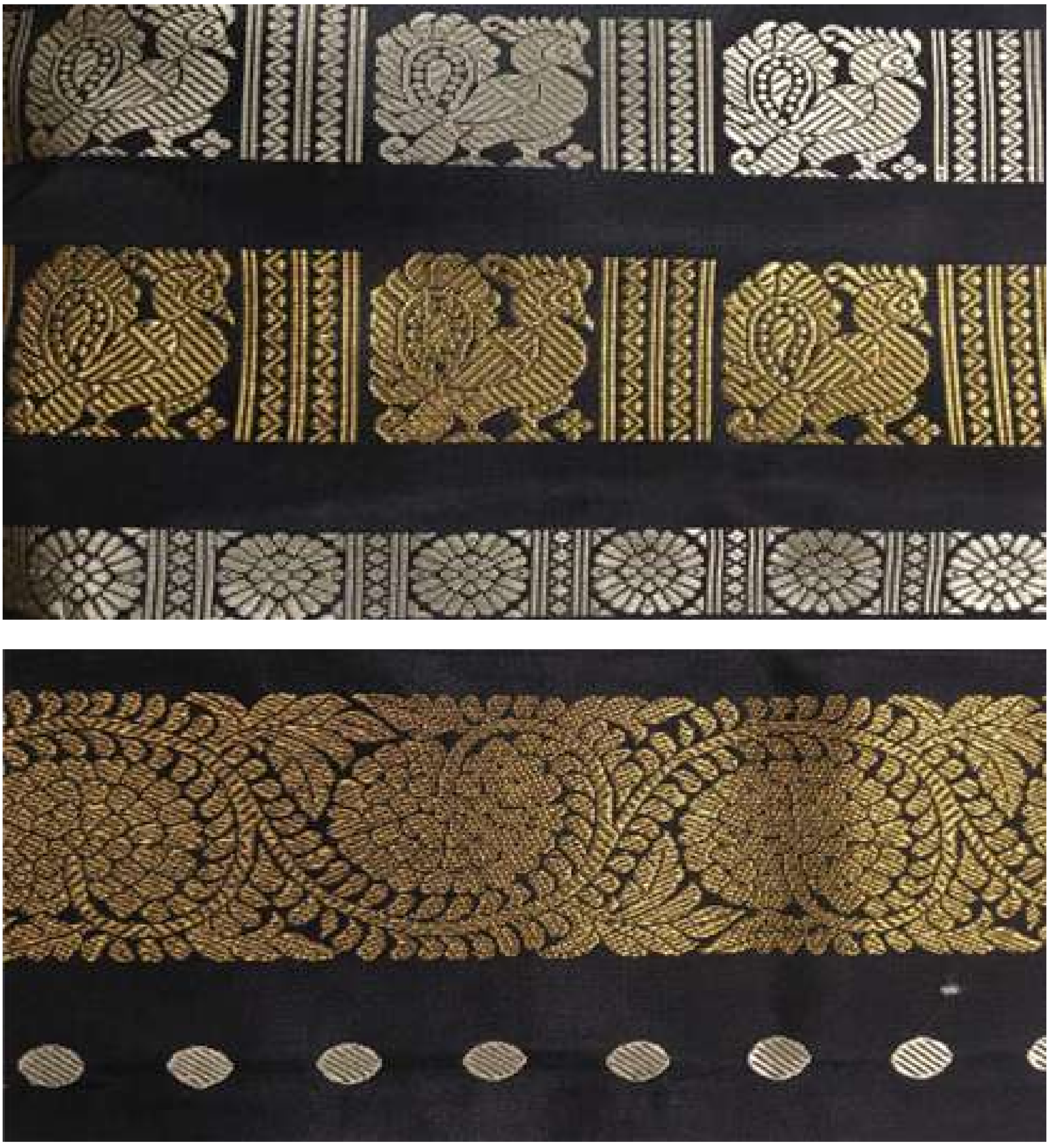
BUILDING A SARI ARCHIVE:
THE WORK OF MASTER WEAVER
B. KRISHNAMOORTHY



B. Krishnamoorthy, a fourth-generation silk weaver from Kancheepuram, has dedicated his life to preserving and reimagining India’s rich handloom heritage. He began learning the craft at the age of 12, assisting in his family’s weaving household while still in school. After completing his studies, he trained under his father, grandfather, and other skilled weavers, mastering both weaving and intricate techniques such as jala work. Early experiences as an apprentice and later as a weaving coordinator helped him understand the craft from multiple perspectives.



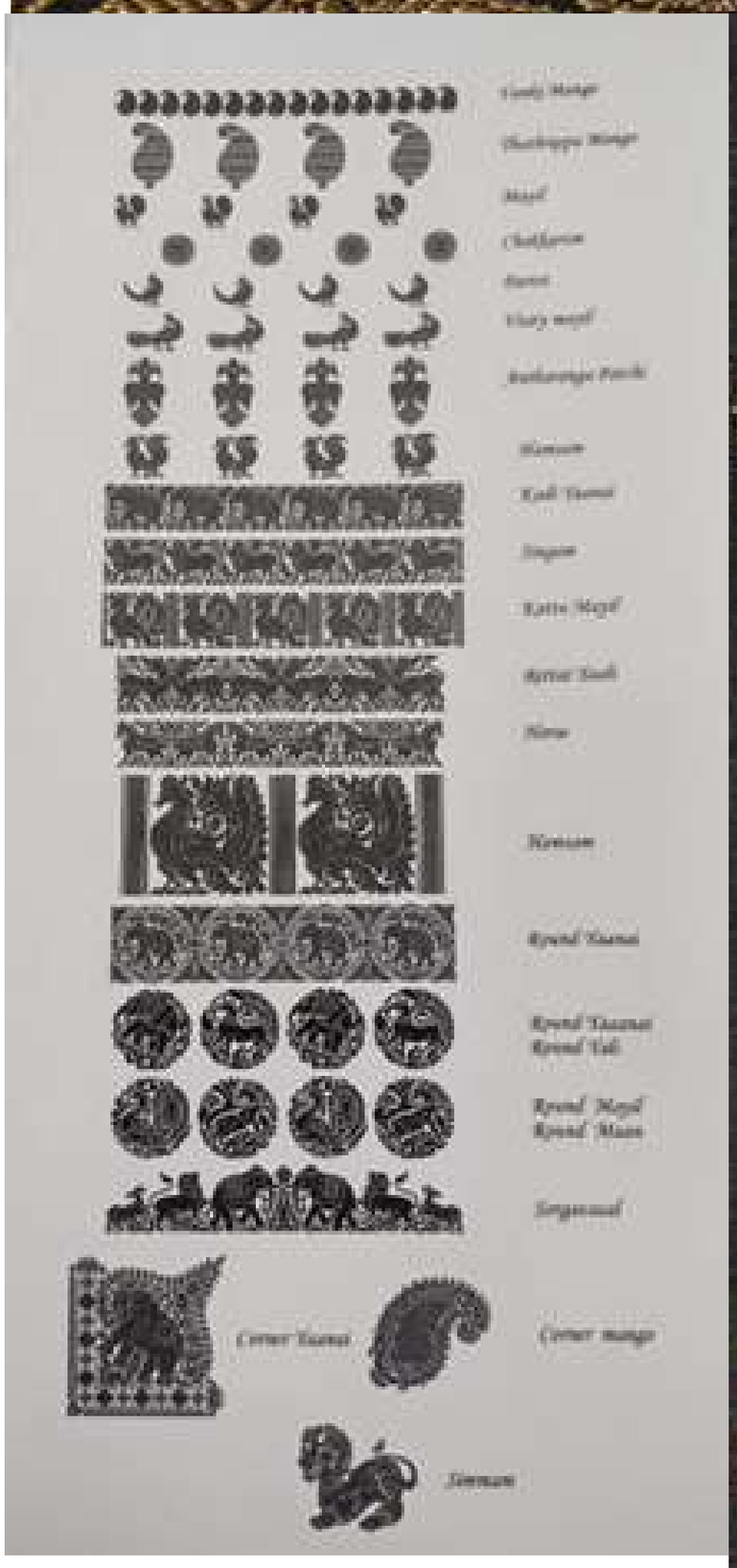
At the request of his students,
Krishnamoorthy chose 114 select motifs,
gathered from ancient sources…



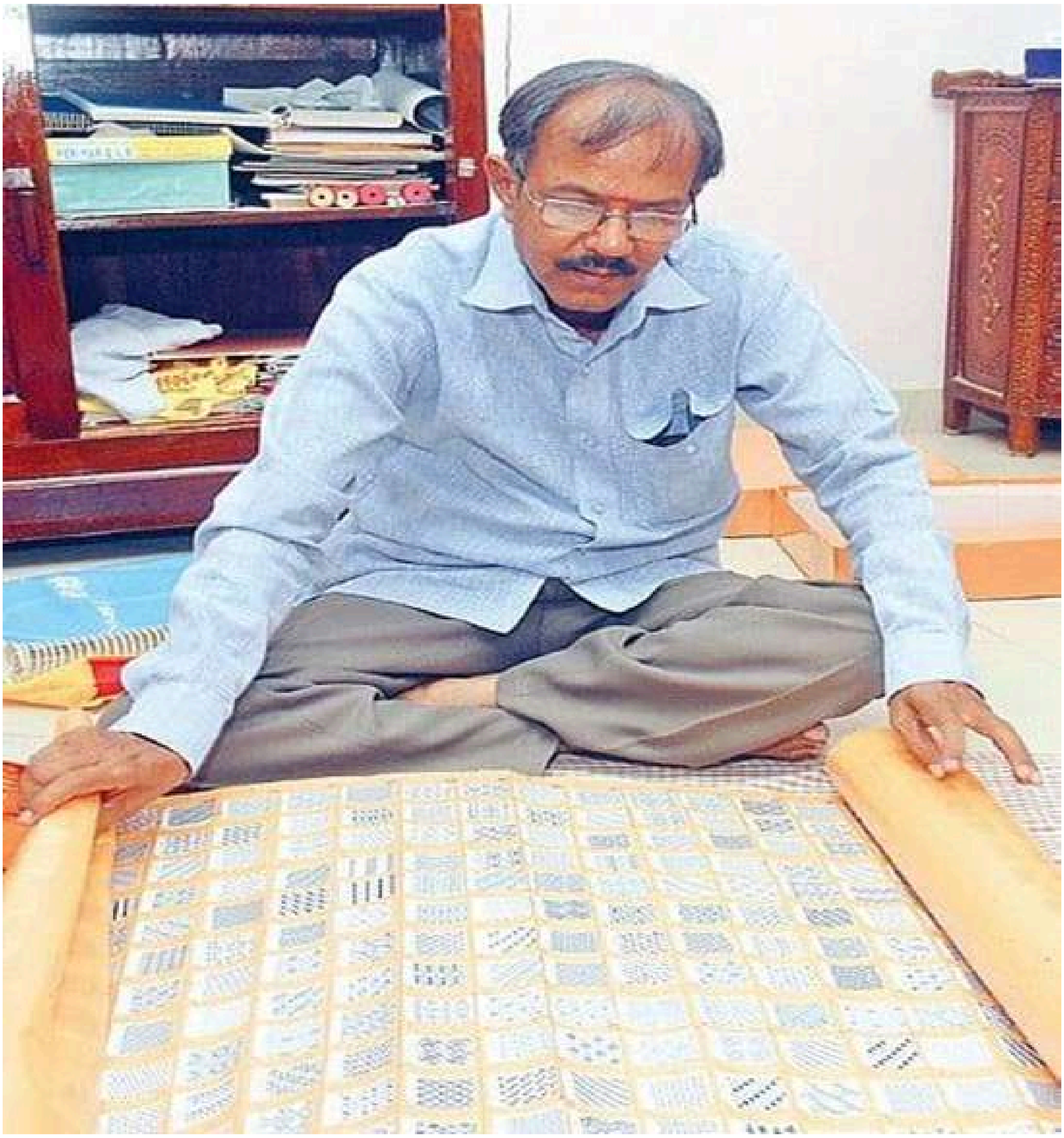
…recreating them in striking silver and gold

At 21, Krishnamoorthy joined Co-optex, where his career took shape. Over 24 years, he grew from a weaver into an accomplished designer, travelling across Tamil Nadu to study traditional weaving styles. He developed popular saree lines such as Puthinam and Kalakshetra patterns, blending tradition with innovation. His time at Co-optex not only refined his artistic and technical skills but also laid the foundation for his lifelong commitment to design and experimentation.




Kasavu
Kasavu
Kasavu

A National Award-winning artisan, Krishnamoorthy is also a self-taught archivist and educator. He has created over 10,000 intricate hand-drawn designs, filling notebooks with motifs inspired by nature, mythology, and temple architecture—parrots, peacocks, elephants, coins, flowers, and the mythical yali. Many of these designs are inherited from earlier generations, while others are his own reinterpretations. His work is widely used by both cooperative societies and private weaving centres.

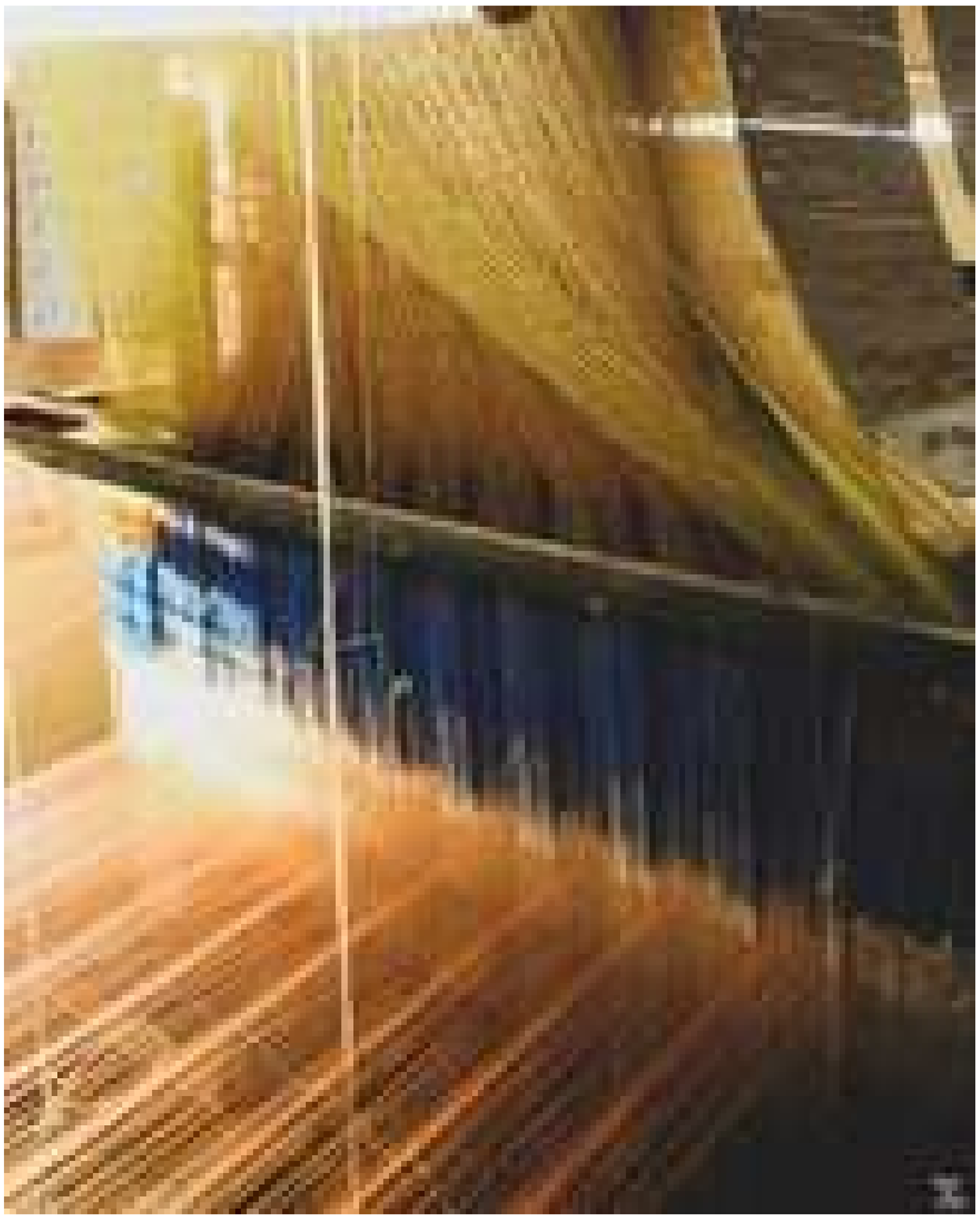




108 figures woven into intricate, glimmering silver squares. The solid black border and classic ‘bavaanchi’ zari band in the pallu accentuate the dramatic concept of the saree

Deeply aware of the collaborative nature of his craft, he documented the making of a Kancheepuram saree, identifying 219 contributors —from mulberry farmers and dyers to zari makers and even electricity providers. This reflects his holistic understanding of weaving as a collective art form rooted in community effort.







Among his most extraordinary creations is a 25-metre silk saree featuring 5,000 unique, non-repeating designs. Taking two years and significant personal savings to complete, this “life project” was not made for sale but as a lasting repository of design—a “library” for future generations. He regularly shares his knowledge with students from design institutes, believing that weaving must be taught early and integrated into formal education to ensure its survival.







In recognition of his lifelong contribution to Indian textiles, Krishnamoorthy was honoured with the Kamala Samman lifetime award acknowledging not only his mastery as a weaver and designer but also his tireless efforts to document, innovate, and pass on the legacy of handloom weaving to future generations.

THE CRAFTS COUNCIL OF INDIA

Kamala Samman

2024 - 2025

Shri B Krishnamoorthy

The Kamala Samman Award instituted by The Crafts Council of India in the year 2000, honours a senior craft activist's lifelong commitment to the cause of India's craft heritage-in-continuum and its artisan creators.

B. Krishnamoorthy, master weaver, traditional silk saree designer and heritage design activist, is a third-generation Kanchipuram silk weaver. The depth, grandeur and artistic elegance of his weaving skills have made him a legend in his own lifetime.

Beginning his craft and conceptual design journey at the age of 15, B. Krishnamoorthy soon mastered weaving techniques and began his journey as a pattern maker and creator of traditional Kanchipuram motifs, as well as a documenter of silk saree designs.

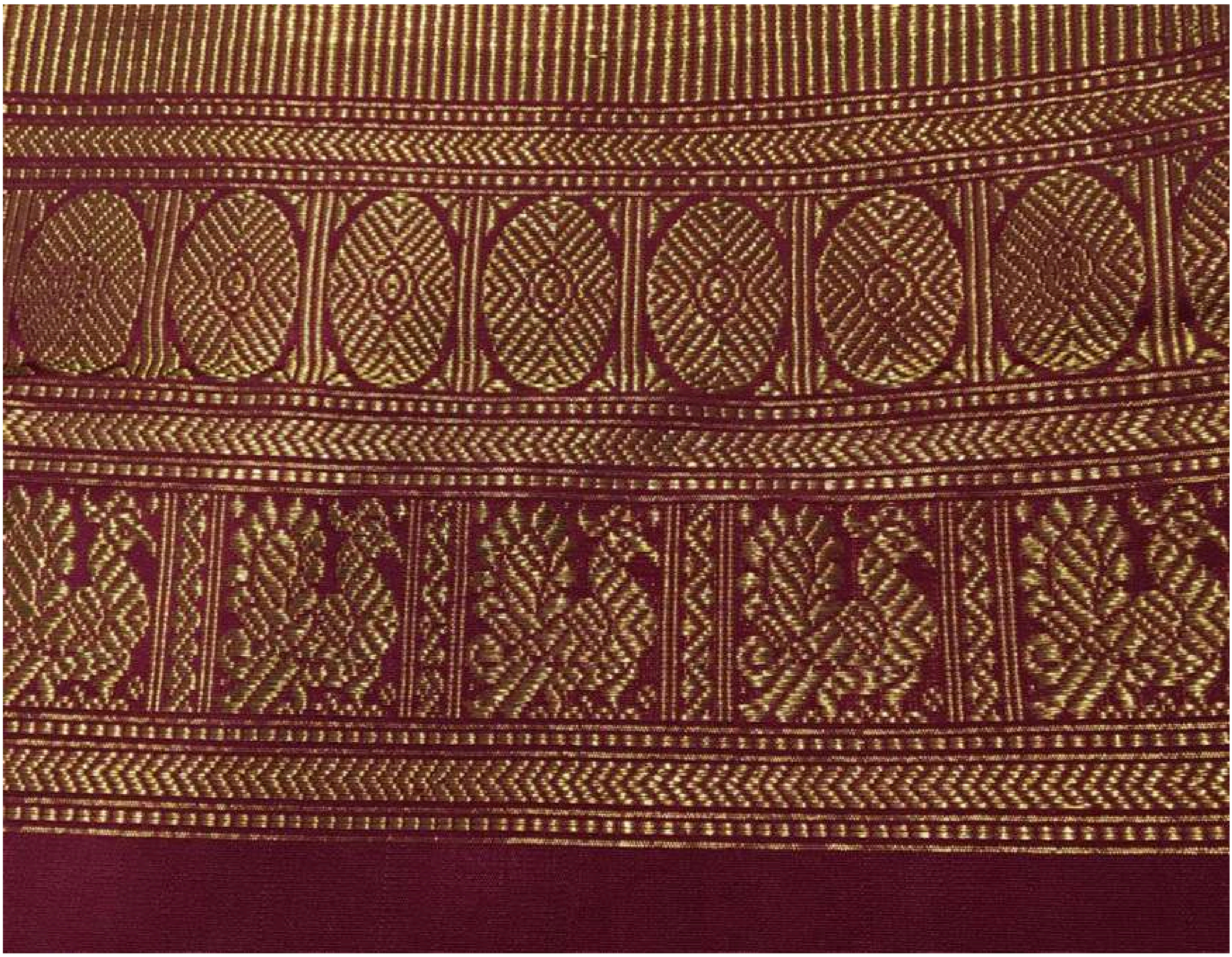
Among his notable achievements is the creation of a 25-metre-long design archive featuring 5,015 traditional motifs and 144 varieties of Kanchipuram borders and "pallus" in a single saree and the creation of more than 10,000 unique hand-drawn motifs including peacocks, elephants, horses and yali.

He has also mentored students from NIFT, Stella Maris, Anna University and other institutions. His journey of creating Kanchipuram saree masterpieces continues...

The Crafts Council of India takes pride in conferring the Kamala Samman Award on Shri B Krishnamoorthy



The crowning glory of the master designer's lifelong endeavour to leave a legacy. A 5000-motif, 25 m, 60" width of woven heritage, a veritable encyclopedia of motifs, 2017



The fastidious teacher records, sketches and transfers every thread of every elaborate design on graph paper for posterity

Sources

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- Kamala, Crafts Council of India
- NIFT